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Mentoring Without Borders: Scaling-Up Leadership Development Through Digital

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Abstract

In today's fast-paced and ever-evolving corporate landscape shaped by digital transformation and the rise of AI – leadership and soft skills development are more crucial than ever. As organizations transition from baby boomers to millennials and Gen Z, first-time managers and senior leaders face unique challenges. These generations bring diverse perspectives and expectations to the workplace, necessitating a shift in leadership development strategies.

Mentoring has emerged as a key enabler in bridging generational and experiential gaps. However, in a global organization with diverse business lines and geographically dispersed teams, traditional mentoring models often fall short. Digital applications offer a powerful solution. They enable organizations to extend mentoring programs beyond physical boundaries, democratize access to leadership development, and embed cultural values across geographies.

In 2022, SLB launched its first global leadership mentoring program WeLead – to democratize access to mentorship and foster a culture of continuous learning. This paper examines the role of digital technology in scaling leadership development, with a focus on how SLB's WeLead program leveraged a custom-built Power App to connect senior leaders with emerging talent across 150+ global locations. The program not only accelerated leadership growth but also became a strategic lever for cultural transformation.

Introduction

Leadership today looks nothing like it did a decade ago: the demand for agile, inclusive, and scalable leadership development has never been greater. The workplace is evolving at lightning speed. AI technologies are reshaping how we work, hybrid teams are the new norm, and younger generations are stepping into leadership roles with fresh expectations. They want purpose, flexibility, and growth – and they want it now.

But here's the challenge: how do you prepare thousands of emerging leaders across dozens of countries, business lines, and time zones? How do you ensure that the wisdom of your most experienced leaders doesn't stay locked in boardrooms or headquarters? That's the question we asked ourselves at SLB. And the answer wasn't yet another classroom or webinar. It was something more human – and more scalable.

Value of mentoring is also long recognized by Fortune 500 companies not only to improve talent attraction and talent retention but also to accelerate employee development for both mentors and mentees. In 2023, 92% of Fortune 500 companies offered mentoring programs, while in 2024 this number reached 98% for the US Fortune 500 companies (Gross 2023). Generally, a consistent accelerating growth effect of such programs was observed. Furthermore, during large scale layoffs in 2022, there was a growth trend of about 8% in the companies that did offer mentoring opportunities. These numbers highlight the amazing potential that could be unlocked by continuous support of the employees' development (L. Francis 2023).

This entry builds on the previous publication by authors on value of mentoring for accelerating culture adoption in a major corporation (Poole, 2024) showcasing value of digital technologies to scale mentoring across the entire organization.

For the global and multinational companies though traditional mentoring programs, while impactful, often struggle with limitations in reach, consistency, and accessibility. We needed a solution that could reach everyone, everywhere. In an era defined by digital transformation, the way organizations develop leaders must evolve. Traditional mentoring models, while valuable, often fall short in today's fast-paced, hybrid, and globally distributed work environments. The challenge is no longer just about offering mentoring opportunities; it's about delivering them at scale, with speed, and in a way that resonates with a digitally native workforce. During the pandemic years, employees were mostly working from home thus being even more separated from the headquarters than in usual times. To address these challenges, organizations began seeking solutions that could transcend the boundaries of time zones, hierarchies, and cultural silos. The imperative became clear: leadership development had to be as dynamic and borderless as the workforce it served.

With the launch of the WeLead leadership mentoring program, we reimagined leadership mentoring as a digitally enabled, socially connected, and learning-integrated experience. The goal was to create a platform that not only connected mentors and mentees across geographies but also embedded leadership development into the daily flow of work. As our understanding of digital mentoring matured, a critical question surfaced: should we adopt an off-the-shelf solution or invest in building our own platform tailored to our unique organizational DNA? The decision was not just technological—it was fundamentally strategic. While numerous external platforms offered robust functionality, none could fully integrate with our existing digital infrastructure or reflect the nuances of our business lines, cultural values, and security requirements. We recognized that a one-size-fits-all approach would fall short of delivering the seamless, highly contextualized experience required by our workforce. Each region, function, and cohort of emerging leaders at SLB comes with its own history, communication style, and development needs. We needed a platform nimble enough to support local adaptation while maintaining global standards and compliance. Data security and privacy were also non-negotiable; an in-house solution would give us the highest degree of control over sensitive organizational information, ensuring compliance with both internal policies and diverse international regulations. Moreover, we wanted a platform that could evolve alongside us: a living, breathing system, capable of integrating new technologies like AI-driven data analytics, customized dashboards, and future learning tools as our leadership development strategy advanced. Building internally allowed us to co-create with our end users, drawing on feedback from mentors and mentees to continually refine features, enhance accessibility, and foster engagement.

By building our own mentoring platform, Welead created a solution deeply aligned with the aspirations and needs of our people, reinforcing mentoring as a central part of slb culture. This wasn't about following trends—it was about shaping the future of leadership through a digital ecosystem that offers inclusive, accessible mentorship to every aspiring leader, regardless of location. WeLead evolved into more than a mentoring program; it became a scalable, digital-first leadership development system that connects people, grows leaders, and strengthens culture globally. Digital mentoring platform has transformed how organizations support development, enabling real-time connections across geographies and functions. Freed from the limits of proximity and rigid schedules, employees can now build relationships and co-create

learning journeys tailored to their goals. Features like matching algorithms, asynchronous communication, and feedback tools make mentoring flexible and personalized. Beyond scalability, this platform fosters inclusivity, supports talent mobility, and embeds growth into everyday work. It also promotes cross-cultural exchange and diverse perspectives, enriching both individuals and organizations.

This paper explores how digital infrastructure enabled SLB to accelerate leadership readiness, foster cultural alignment, and build a connected community of learners and leaders.

Business Case: Why Digital Mentoring Matters More Than Ever

The Challenge of Connection in a Changing World

Mentoring has long been recognized as a cornerstone of professional and personal development. In recent years, its relevance has grown significantly, particularly as organizations navigate the complexities of a multigenerational workforce, digital transformation, and evolving leadership expectations. According to LinkedIn's 2023 Workplace Learning Report, mentorship programs ranked as the top priority in learning and development (L&D) strategies, reflecting a broader shift toward experiential and relationship-based learning (Cai, 2023). The benefits of mentoring are well-documented. For mentees, it enhances confidence, accelerates career progression, and improves mental well-being. For mentors, it provides opportunities for reflection, legacy-building, and leadership reinforcement. For organizations, mentoring fosters a culture of collaboration, inclusion, and continuous learning: key attributes for resilience and innovation in today's business environment.

The COVID-19 pandemic further underscored the importance of human connection and experiential learning. As remote work became the norm, organizations recognized the limitations of traditional training models and the need for more personalized, flexible, and scalable development solutions. Mentoring, particularly when enabled by digital platforms, emerged as a powerful response. COVID-19 period in-person working restrictions also helped accelerate development of digital engagement tools & environments and equally important virtual remote networking best practices. What was long believed to be possible and efficient only in person overnight became a norm via virtual communication channels. This shift in communication best practices created a possibility of connecting first-time managers and aspiring leaders based in a remote location, far from the company's headquarters who are eager to grow, but unsure where to start with senior leaders with decades of experience is looking for ways to give back, to share lessons learned, and to shape the next generation of leaders. The challenge is what would it take to make mentoring accessible to every leader in our organization – no matter where they are or what they do? The answer was clear: we needed to remove friction, eliminate bias, and make it easy to connect. That's the "why" behind WeLead.

In a world where leadership is no longer confined to titles or locations, organizations must find ways to bridge generational, geographical, and functional divides. The rise of AI technologies, hybrid work, and digital transformation has made this even more urgent. Leadership today is about adaptability, empathy, and continuous learning and mentoring is one of the most effective ways to cultivate those traits.

Anticipated Organizational Impact

At SLB, the WeLead digital mentoring program was designed to address these evolving needs. By providing hands-on, practical exposure to leadership behaviors and cultural values, the program enhances employee readiness for leadership roles and strengthens retention. This is particularly critical for first-time managers and emerging leaders, who represent a significant portion of the company's future leadership pipeline.

Cost Efficiency and Retention Benefits

External research indicates that mentoring participants have retention rates over 20% higher than non-participants (Together Team, 2022) and are 70% more likely to remain with their company for more than

five years (Harvard Business Review, 2022). Given the high cost of turnover, especially in leadership roles, retaining even a small number of employees through mentoring can yield substantial savings. For example, preventing the departure of just six early-career leaders could save the organization over USD 1 million annually in recruitment, onboarding, and training costs. These figures do not account for the additional benefits of improved business continuity, customer satisfaction, and team morale.

Accelerating Culture Adoption and Career Development

WeLead's structure is based on leadership circles and cross-functional mentoring—facilitates knowledge transfer across levels, functions, and geographies. As "culture eats strategy for breakfast" (Peter Drucker), SLB is working on development of its own culture and its adoption and efficient spreading inside the company. WeLead mentoring program does not only accelerate the adoption of SLB's leadership culture but also fosters innovation by breaking down silos and encouraging diverse perspectives. The program targets employees in leadership roles across the organization, from new managers to seasoned leaders, representing approximately one-third of the workforce. Enhancing the leadership capabilities of this critical group has a multiplier effect, influencing teams and shaping the broader organizational culture.

Methodology: Scaling with Purpose Through Digital

We didn't just digitize mentoring – we reimaged it.

We knew that a single application, on its own, would not be enough. Instead, our approach centered on building a true digital ecosystem: one that leverages every corporate digital channel to create a seamless mentoring experience accessible to all. Rather than isolating mentoring within a standalone tool, we orchestrated a network of interconnected platforms: from a custom-built digital app to internal social media networks and communications channels, to robust virtual collaboration spaces including online meeting platforms, webinars, file sharing sites, internal chat tools, and comprehensive virtual learning environments.

This ecosystem was intentionally designed to integrate into the daily flow of work, making mentoring not an isolated event, but an ongoing, accessible, and dynamic exchange. Our bespoke Power App became the central hub, but it was only the beginning. Mentors and mentees could connect and communicate instantly via internal social channels, schedule sessions and share insights in virtual meeting rooms, and access curated resources and learning modules through dedicated SharePoint sites and our virtual learning platform. Webinars and global town halls provided opportunities for group learning, while chats groups enabled informal, ongoing dialogue that kept momentum alive between formal mentoring sessions. By activating every digital touchpoint, we ensured that mentoring relationships could flourish regardless of location, role, or schedule. This holistic digital infrastructure eliminated silos and barriers, enabling a culture of continuous leadership development. The WeLead program was built on the principle that **technology should enhance – not replace human connection**. To achieve this, we designed a digital-first mentoring experience that was intuitive, inclusive, and deeply integrated into the organization's digital workplace as well as having some in-person connections too.



Figure 1—Welead Mentoring Program Ecosystem

Principal elements of the methodology include:

Centralized Digital Platform (Power App)

A tailored Power App functioned as the primary hub for managing all mentoring activities. This unified, single-sign-on solution provided an intuitive onboarding experience for both mentors and mentees.

Key features of the app:

Mentor-mentee matching: WeLead has a unique topic-based matching to eliminate bias and ensure relevance. Instead of pairing people based on job titles or departments or allowing mentees to choose the mentors from their own business lines or geographical locations, we matched them based on leadership topics they cared about. For example, time & energy management, strategic thinking, or managing diverse teams. This double-blind approach removed unconscious bias but also created instantaneous connections not only with mentor but also within the group of mentees, as all of them have selected the same mentoring topic of interest. Such an objective approach resulted in high level of engagement while enabling participants' diversity & varied perspectives. Currently one Mentor is connected with upto 4 mentees in one virtual circle. Mentor and mentees have 4 live group discussion sessions.

Integrated session scheduling experience: The Power App is synchronized with corporate calendars, email and on-line meeting platforms for seamless scheduling and on-line meeting experience. Recommended Mentoring cycle is 9 weeks with 3 weeks gap between sessions.

Goal setting: In any mentoring relationship, clarity of purpose is key. Digital platforms allow mentees and mentors to define specific goals at the outset, whether it's improving communication skills, preparing for a leadership role, or navigating a career transition. Goal setting helped us transform mentoring from a casual conversation into a structured development journey. It aligns expectations, focuses discussions, and helps participants measure progress.

Digital advantage: In WeLead, goals are embedded into the app interface, making them visible, editable, and trackable. This ensures that both parties remain aligned and accountable throughout the mentoring cycle.

Feedback collection: Feedback is the bridge between experience and learning. In traditional mentoring, feedback is often informal and undocumented. Digital platforms change that by enabling structured, real-time feedback after each session. WeLead uses integrated feedback forms and rating systems, allowing for immediate input after each interaction. This data is aggregated and analyzed to improve content, session's structure, and support resources. Over the last two years we have collected over 2000 feedback responses.

They helped mentors refine their approach and gave mentees a voice in shaping their experience. It also provided program administrators with insights into session quality, engagement levels, and topic relevance.

Real-Time Analytics: Using Power BI, program administrators could monitor participation rates, topic popularity, session quality, and user satisfaction. This data-driven approach allowed for continuous improvement and ensured alignment with organizational goals. This strategic use of digital technology integrated into corporate tools communication channels allowed us to make mentoring scalable, inclusive, and impactful across a global organization.

Social Communication Channels

To foster engagement and community, the program leveraged internal social platforms used to:

- Share success stories and mentoring tips.
- Promote upcoming webinars and leadership events.
- Enable peer-to-peer learning and informal knowledge exchange.

This social layer created a sense of belonging and visibility, encouraging participants to stay active and connected between sessions.

Integrated Digital Learning Materials

Mentoring sessions were supported by a curated library of **digital learning resources**, including:

- Leadership articles, book chapters, videos and toolkits.
- Recorded webinars and panel discussions.
- Interactive learning pathways aligned with SLB's leadership competencies.

These materials were embedded directly into the mentoring app and accessible on demand, allowing participants to **learn at their own pace** and apply insights in real time.

Scalable Structure and Global Reach

The program was designed to scale from the outset. With a structured approach based on 23 leadership topics, participants could tailor their mentoring journey to their specific development needs. The digital infrastructure enabled rapid expansion: from 12 mentoring circles during initial manually managed pilot run in only 3 locations up to 30 mentoring circles in 38 locations at the launch of digital app with 100 users to over 2,000 users in 150+ locations. Whether you were a mentor or mentee, you had a clear path to follow, and the flexibility to make it your own. The digital infrastructure enabled rapid expansion: from 12 mentoring circles during initial manually managed pilot run in only 3 locations up to 30 mentoring circles in 38 locations at the launch of digital app with 100 users to over 2,000 users in 150+ locations. Typical Mentoring circle consists of 4 sessions with Intro and Follow-up session structure for 2 topics. [Figure 2](#) below illustrates the full cycle from scheduling to next circle sign up.

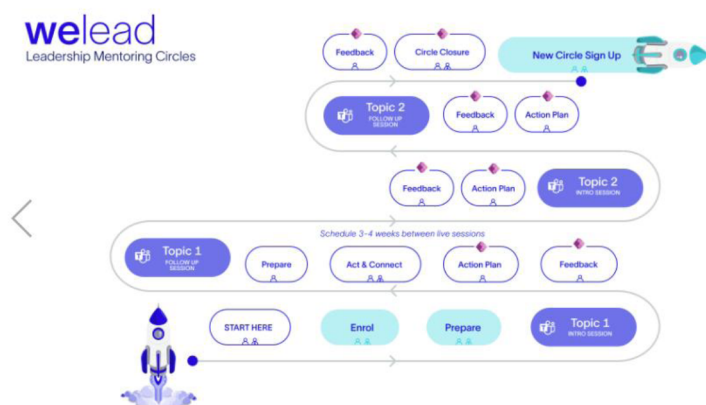


Figure 2—Leadership Circles Participant Journey

Largely self-service digital infrastructure requires reasonably small effort from program administrators while ensuring user friendly approach consistent across all locations.

Community and Culture

Beyond on-line small group mentoring sessions, we hosted global events, webinars with C-suite leaders, and shared stories across our internal platforms. It isn't just a program—it is a movement.

To summarize the methodology, our approach centered on strategically leveraging all available corporate communication channels to amplify the program's reach and impact. By harnessing the immediacy and community-building strength of internal social media platforms to orchestrating targeted webinars that united leaders and participants from across the globe, we ensured that the WeLead initiative permeated every layer of the organization. This multi-channel strategy was not just about relaying information; it was about weaving a digital fabric that connected individuals who might never meet face-to-face, cultivating a sense of belonging and shared purpose across geographical boundaries. By breaking through siloes, transcending departments, time zones, and even languages we made knowledge of the program ubiquitous. Stories, successes, and lessons learned circulated swiftly in real time, enabling employees everywhere to engage with, learn from, and contribute to the movement. These deliberate communication efforts transformed the mentoring program from an isolated initiative into a global conversation, fueling continual growth, innovation, and authentic connection across SLB's expansive footprint.

Insight: The Critical Role of User Experience in Digital Mentoring

The success and continued growth of the WeLead program hinged on delivering a seamless, engaging user experience, one that would spark initial interest and sustain long-term participation from both mentors and mentees. Early on, the quality of our digital tools, particularly the custom-built Power App, proved pivotal in shaping user perceptions and behaviors. From the earliest days of WeLead, digital tools were instrumental in driving rapid onboarding and expanding the program's reach. Our first proof of concept trial run using manual mentor mentee matching and scheduling allowed us only to accommodate 10 mentoring circles in just 3 locations back in 2021. Building custom made power app to fit the program objectives allowed us to scale dramatically from the very early days of the program launch.

Since its launch in May 2022, the WeLead program has demonstrated significant success in scaling leadership development across SLB's global footprint. The program expanded from an initial 130 users in 38 locations to over 2,000 active participants in more than 150 locations worldwide within its first 18 months. This rapid growth underscores the scalability and accessibility of the digital mentoring model. One of the key lessons learned was the importance of a sustained, high-quality user experience soon became evident. While the early versions facilitated growth, they were not fully stable and lacked full seamless integration

with corporate scheduling and email systems. This led to member dissatisfaction and retention challenges as users encountered scheduling difficulties and missed communications.

Recognizing this, we prioritized continuous feedback, quickly gathering and acting on user input. The development team worked closely with stakeholders to address pain points, culminating in a complete overhaul of the app in 2024. The new version not only aligned with SLB's refreshed brand identity but, more importantly, significantly boosted stability and enhanced the overall user experience. Features such as intuitive navigation, streamlined scheduling, and curated digital learning paths tailored to leadership topics made participation far more accessible and rewarding. The revamped version was built on a more stable backend and fully integrated with company calendars and email platforms, ensuring frictionless scheduling and communication experience. Alongside these technical improvements, we enhanced the user interface and enriched the notification system, both within the app and through email, resulting in a far more intuitive and rewarding user journey.

The current solution is a comprehensive digital mentoring platform, anchored by a centralized Power App and supported by integrated applications that enable social engagement, collaboration, and learning. A suite of customized analytics dashboards delivers actionable insights to mentors, mentees, program administrators, and HR leadership. Figure 3 illustrates this connected digital mentoring ecosystem.

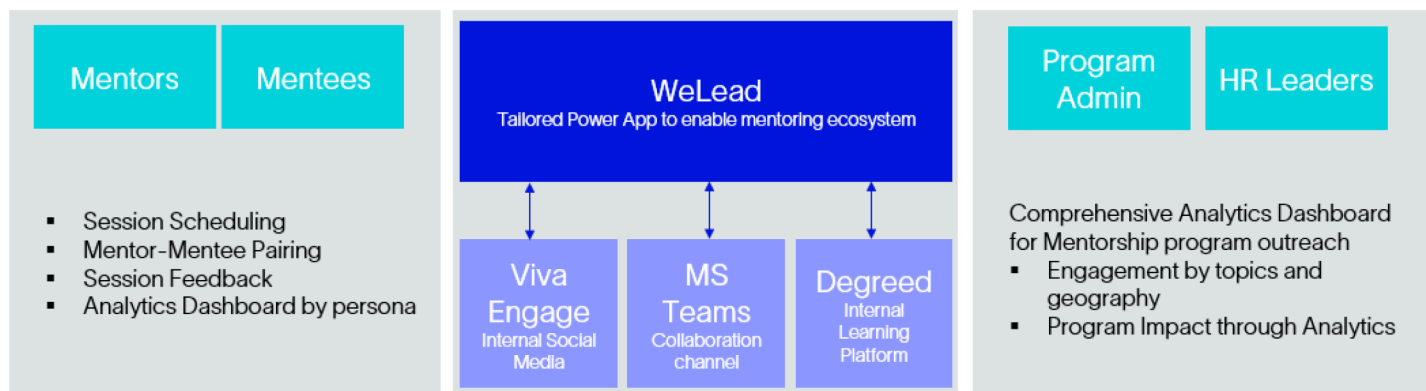


Figure 3—Digital Mentoring with WeLead Power-app as connector and enabler

The impact of this user friendly, connected digital platform was immediate and significant. Session ratings and overall user satisfaction rose notably, reflecting not only operational improvements but also the program's strategic alignment with SLB's broader goals: leadership readiness, cultural integration, and talent retention. Figure 4 below shows positive trends observed from over 2000 feedback collected to date on quality of material, level of engagements between mentors and mentees contributing to overall session ratings. Noticeable dip observed in 2024 corresponded to challenges with app and user experience which have been rectified. The average session feedback rose to 9.4 out of 10, reflecting both the improved quality of supporting materials and the deepening mentor-mentee connections.

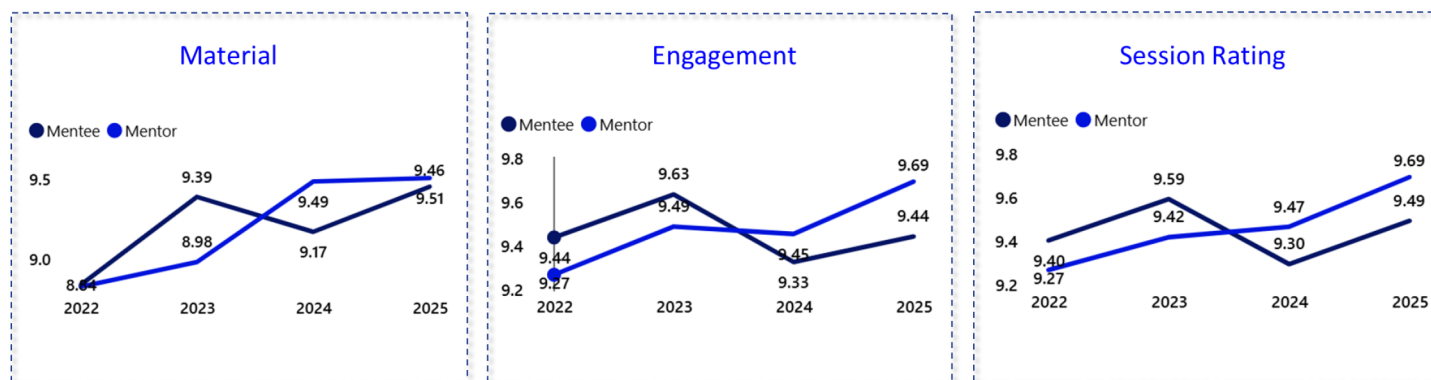


Figure 4—Program performance indicators based on users' feedback

As the app's stability improved, we observed marked increases in user engagement, retention, and satisfaction. Key achievements included a rapid expansion in program scale: from 130 users in 38 locations to over 2,000 participants across more than 150 global sites within 18 months. More than 4,000 mentoring hours were delivered across 23 structured leadership topics, fueled by robust participation and consistently high session ratings as shown on figure 5. This underscored a crucial lesson: even with a strong program design, the effectiveness of digital mentoring relies fundamentally on the reliability and usability of the supporting technology.



Figure 5—Learning hours distribution by topic

In essence, investing in high-quality, user-friendly digital infrastructure was not just a technical upgrade, it was a strategic enabler that transformed WeLead into a truly scalable, inclusive, and impactful movement. The positive trends in engagement and outcomes following the app's enhancement validated our commitment to user experience as the foundation for sustainable program success.

Conclusion: A Culture of Growth, Powered by Technology

WeLead's innovative approach lies in its use of digital technology to scale-up mentoring across a global organization. The holistic ecosystem of digital tools allows users seamless access to online learning materials. Social media platforms, paired with a library of webinars and past events, enable experience sharing and connection between sessions. The core of the program is a user-friendly digital application: a single login tool for session scheduling, mentor-mentee matching, goal setting, and continuous feedback plus performance monitoring enabled by Power App and Power BI analytics. In conclusion, WeLead exemplifies how digital mentoring can scale-up leadership development across a global organization, foster a culture of continuous learning and development and prepare SLB's leaders for the challenges of tomorrow. By leveraging Digital Power App technology, we brought the concept of borderless mentoring to life -

fostering social mobility and forging meaningful connections between senior leaders in main offices to first time managers and young leaders in remote locations.

WeLead is a complete mentoring ecosystem that's inclusive, data-driven, and deeply human.

- **Inclusive:** Anyone in a leadership role, regardless of location or function, can join as a mentor, and any aspiring leader can join as a mentee.
- **Data-Driven:** With Power BI analytics, we track engagement, feedback, and topic trends in real time.
- **Human-Centered:** Every interaction is designed to foster growth, reflection, and connection.

WeLead isn't just a program – it's a cultural accelerator. It's how we scale leadership, embed values, and prepare our people for the future. And it all started with one simple belief: mentoring should have no borders.

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